



**IPL**  
**PLAYER OF THE FORTNIGHT**

# SCORCHING SIRAJ

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**A**fter being snubbed from India's Champions Trophy squad, Mohammed Siraj has come back hungrier than ever, picking nine wickets in four matches and setting up Gujarat Titans' three back-to-back wins in the IPL this season. Six of

Siraj's nine wickets came in the PowerPlay and helped set the tone for the Titans. During this phase, Siraj nabbed key batters such as Rohit Sharma, Phil Salt, Abhishek Sharma, and Travis Head, leaving the opposition reeling early on.

Siraj has also made the most of the lifting of the saliva ban this year, using reverse swing to keep the run-scoring in check at the death and picking crucial wickets during this phase. The 31-year-old is someone who can get carried away by the lure of picking early wickets, but he has shown exemplary control in the tournament so far, pitching 70 of his 96 balls in the back-of-a-length and good-length areas, which have accounted for seven of his nine scalps. He has erred on the fuller side only eight times and dished out full tosses just twice.

That Siraj is on a mission to prove a point was evident during his spell against his former franchise, Royal Challengers Bengaluru, when he picked 3/19 to silence the raucous M. Chinnaswamy Stadium crowd — one that egged him on for seven seasons. He then stunned the fans in his hometown of Hyderabad by tearing through Sunrisers with a career-best haul of 4/17. While Siraj has been ever-present in India's white-ball attack over the last few years, an unforeseen axing was just the break he needed to unleash a more potent avatar.

*(All stats up to date as of April 8)*

**MATCHES**

**4**

**WICKETS**

**9**

**BBM**

**4/17**

**ECO**

**7.75**



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